the emotional quotient. "Otherwise, it is becoming a history lesson," he adds. "They are the soul of it." Leading the proceedings is Kanti, a London-educated lawyer who finds his conscience shaken as he unravels the truth. Madhvani sums up his transformative arc from that of "a suit to a dhoti".

The Waking of a Nation goes for a no-holds-barred approach in showing how the occupiers perceived the occupied, referring to them as "uncivilised natives" and "savages", and focusing on the British antagonists in Punjab's then Lt Governor Michael O'Dwyer and General Reginald Dyer, who ordered the firing on innocent civilians. While Dyer, Madhvani adds, became "the fall guy", O'Dwyer was the "ringleader" who orchestrated the mayhem.

For Madhvani, it's important that the show begins a cultural conversation about how Indians were "whitewashed" and also to not just inform but engage the youth. Says Madhvani, "The idea you cannot actually rule yourself, how did we believe that? How did this happen? How did we become who we are? Why were we not made aware about it?" If the show gets the reception that Madhvani and SonyLIV desire, the filmmaker says he already has another episode from pre-independent India which lends itself to a long format treatment—the revolt of 1857. ■

–Suhani Singh



WOMAN POWER

Season 2 of the Tamil crime thriller series *Suzhal*, set against the backdrop of a vibrant local festival, features strong female characters

Small town, big crime, set against a festival. It's Pushkar-Gayatri's succinct one-line description for the Amazon Prime Video series *Suzhal: The Vortex*. In season two, the setting shifts to the seaside town of Kulasekharapatnam in Tamil Nadu, the festival in focus is Ashtakali and the whodunit expands to include more characters. "Our team went hunting for myths, many of which were not documented, and interviewed a bunch of people, especially older ones," says Pushkar. "Few people outside the town know of the festival, so there's something to discover for everyone." As writers they use the age-old myth as "a metaphor" to reflect on a social issue in contemporary times.

It's this sense of wonderment, rootedness and relevance that made season one of the crime thriller one of the best series in 2022. That it happened to be in Tamil and came from one of the industry's popular directors of *Vikram Vedha* fame only enhanced its views. The husband-wife duo's director peers in Chennai are baffled that they continue to embrace the streaming medium when they can easily mount theatrical spectacles in a market that loves its cinema big and worships its stars. "The question of why keeps coming up even now?" says Gayatri. But it's not just the soft corner they both have for the long-format medium that draws them, it's also about the "little more leeway" OTT gives creators.

Created by the husband-wife director duo Pushkar-Gayatri, the show is streaming on Prime Video

"In films there is commerce...budget tied to it," says Gayatri. "Streaming gives us a lot more scope to explore characters." In this case, it is eight women who are all suspects. In fact, Pushkar-Gayatri take great pride in how season two enhances the feminist streak. "A lot of female-centric movies or series get into the relationship thing...there's a personal angst or they are trying to grow up or figure a relationship. That frustrates me," says Gayatri. "The eight women here are not in that cute space but are super strong characters who take things head on." Adds Pushkar, "For us the agency for a character is important, they shouldn't need to seek validation from elsewhere."

Suzhal, for Pushkar and Gayatri, is less small-screen entertainment and more "cinematic television". Their hope is that it gets more Tamil audiences to invest their time in it. "It's not there yet but we are seeing the shift happening and a larger understanding that the space exists," says Pushkar. At their end, they are already developing other projects including a season two of crime thriller *Vadhanidhi*, have another female-centric series shooting, in addition to having finished a script for a film. "These days our team asks us how many pages have you written today?" says Pushkar. Given the quick turnaround time for season two of *Suzhal*, it looks like they are delivering. ■

–Suhani Singh